

L2A™

Q2. (a) Critically discuss the formalist and substantivist approach in the context of economic anthropology

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Economic anthropology analyses, interprets and describes the economic life in socio-cultural contexts at all places and at all times.

There are two schools of thoughts in economic anthropology:

1) Formalist approach

a) main proponents - Herskovitz, Dalton

b) They argued that economic systems of primitive societies can be understood by the principles of economics only which include:-

i) Principle of ~~maxim~~ maximisation :

- Humans in general tend to maximize their resources.

ii) Principle of rationalisation

- Human through rationality perform actions in keeping in mind of profit & loss.

2) Substantivist Approach

a) main proponents - Karl Polanyi, Sahline

b) They argued that underlying basis of economic relations among primitive societies are social.

Hence, anthropologists are best suited to study economic systems of simple societies.

Case study - Malinowski in his work among Trobriand Islanders 'Argonauts of Western Pacific (1922)' talked about Kula exchange.

Despite being an uneconomic venture; tribals perform Kula voyage as it helps to maintain social relationship and reestablishes the bond

Similarly Potlach among Kwakiutl involves large scale destruction of valuables. It may seem uneconomic but helps to maintain social relationship.

Hence in simple economies, social roles score over economic ones.

That's why Sahlins argued:

- i) Gifts do not maximize, rather they optimise
- ii) Money is to west, what kinship is to rest.

• Also Carneiro studied Kuikuro of Amazon, he realised that competition is prohibited in the society. As a result, men only work as much as they need and to not for profit.

However Plattner argued that debate is outdated and there is a need to follow interdisciplinary approach so as to mutually benefit.

Amartya Sen welfare economics can be helpful in understanding role of social relations in deciding economic relations among simple economies.

